

Joseph Rachiele

PHIL 4200: Plato on Pleasure

Dr. Kamtekar

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Pleasure Through Virtue

Throughout Plato's *Laws*, it becomes apparent that pleasure is one of the most complex yet simple topics that he discusses. The concept of pleasure is accessible to understand in the sense that everyone has the capacity to experience and recognize it. Yet pleasure is also difficult to understand, since experiences of pleasure are not shared uniformly and depend upon how individuals distinguish what they believe counts as pleasurable. In *Laws II* section 659a-664c and *Laws V* section 732d-734e, the Athenian's dialogue suggests that Plato is promoting the idea that virtue can provide pleasure. It is up to the discretion of the agent to determine whether something is pleasurable or not and to determine what life is most pleasurable, what life is best, and what life they ought to lead. By choosing to follow virtue, namely justice, Plato's writing demonstrates that the virtuous life is the most pleasurable. Through the Athenian's dialogue in *Laws* and the natures of virtue and pleasure, Plato demonstrates that pursuing a virtuous life brings about more pleasure in one's life than a life where pleasure is the main object of pursuit. This argument is supported by objectivity of virtue and forms of the good, avoidance of false pleasures, complete satisfaction of the soul, and the blessings from the gods all associated with the following of a virtuous life.

In *Laws V*, Plato presents foundational principles for the choice of lives and basic framework for how each human ought to approach pleasure. From these principles, he explores what life is the most choiceworthy and why. These principles are:

1. We want pleasure (733a9)
2. We neither choose nor want pain (733b1)
3. We do NOT want what is neither pleasure nor pain in place of pleasure, but we DO want it in place of pain (733b1-3)
4. We want less pain with more pleasure (733b3-4)
5. We do not want less pleasure with more pain (733b4)
6. We would be unable to make clear what we want if offered an exchange of equal amounts of each (733b5-6)
7. All these things that concern our wants vary in number, size, intensity and equality and its opposites. Some of these do and some do not make a difference to our choice between them (733b6-c1)¹

These principles are non-controversial pillars of truth within human desire. In *Laws V*, the Athenian's argument is that a virtuous life is inherently better and more pleasant than a wicked life. There is *prima facie* evidence that the Athenian is not committed to simple ethical hedonism with virtue being the primary objective rather than pure pleasure. From this, the arguments can be made that a virtuous and non-hedonist life is more pleasurable than the hedonic life where pleasure is the end goal. A life in constant pursuit of pleasure will cease at nothing to obtain that pleasure treats pleasure the means as well as the ends. A virtuous life treats virtue rather than pleasures as the end and allows for pleasure as a by-product of obtaining the means. Pleasure takes a different form in each person's life and is defined by that person, which makes for a subjective nature. The objectivity of virtue, and the pursuit of virtue for the sake of itself,

¹ These principles are outlined by James Warren in his work titled "Comparing Lives in Plato, *Laws* 5." For the sake of conciseness I have decided to keep his numbering system the same. These quotes are all directly from *Laws V* and I have provided the accurate Stephanus numbers citation.

promotes a good life since the form of the good is also set in stone and not determined by what we label as pleasurable. Thus, since pleasure can take the form of anything labelled by the agent, individuals ought to pursue a virtuous life such that they obtain what is good and pleasure as a consequence rather than the ultimate aim.

The question remains, what life ought we to pursue if a hedonic life where one pursues the most pleasure is not ideal. Warren presents choices of lives based on their basic hedonic preferences which build upon the initial seven principles Plato originally outlined. First is what he describes as the “Calliclean” life² which Plato outlines in (8). The important feature of the “Calliclean” life is how one seeks the most intense pleasures and is also met with the associated immense pains. A “Calliclean” life is therefore not always in a preponderance of pleasure due to the pain also being amplified in the pursuit of pleasure. The second life is the opposite, referred to as the “quiet” life as seen in (9). A quiet life is distinguishable from the “Calliclean” life because it does not seek the most intense amount of pleasure but rather prefers a smaller quantity in order to preserve the preponderance of pleasure. We will always prefer a life in which the pleasures predominate rather than the pains. The only way of analyzing which life is better is by based on their preponderance or ratio of pleasure to pain, rather, one must discern whether a “Calliclean” or quiet is better on a case by case basis. They are inherently different because they are on different scales of size and intensity. The third life is the “balanced” life³ as described in (10). These three lives are outlined below

² Named after the life that Callicles promotes in *Gorgias* (491e-494c)

³ Greek: “isoroppos” meaning equilibrium

8. Calliclean Life: We want the life in which, while there are many and great and intense pleasures and pains, the pleasures predominate; but we do not want such a life if the pains predominate (733c2-4)
9. Quiet Life: And we want the life in which while the pleasures and pains are few, small, and mild, the pleasures predominate; but we do not want such a life if the pains predominate. (733c4-6)
10. Balanced Life: But in the balanced life then we have to consider things as we did earlier. We want the balanced life in which what predominates is something dear to us but not that in which what predominates are hostile to us. (7633c6-d2)

Warren introduces T.J. Saunders' view, which maintains that the "balanced" life is one in which size, intensity, or numerosity of pleasures and pains is equal. A balance in size refers to the quantity of pleasures and pains, a balance in intensity determines the quality or magnitude of those pleasures and pains, and a balance in numerosity determines the number and frequency of those pleasures and pains (how often they balance). What predominates in a balanced life is not pleasure or pain but rather what is dear to us or what is hostile to us. A balanced life must include aspects at both extremes, many and few, large and small, great and miniscule. This method of comparing lives introduces the idea that there can be a multitude of factors involved in deciding which life to pursue based on pleasure. There are aspects other than pleasure and pain that bear weight in choosing life including but not limited to: fineness, dearness, blessedness, correctness, goodness, excellence, happiness, but most importantly, virtue.⁴ One who recognizes the weight of these other aspects will undoubtedly choose a life aimed at virtue rather than a

⁴ Warren, 337. This section was inspired by Warren's comparison of the wanton life to the life of self-control

vicious or hedonic life because a life where virtue is the end goal takes care of all other aspects that derivatively lead to pleasure. Leading a virtuous life is a holistic approach to life that cares for every part of the mind, body, and soul.

Warren justifies how the quiet life will more often provide predominance of pleasure than the Calliclean life. This happens because the quiet life is the life of virtue rather than vice. Virtue is objective and pure in nature whereas pleasure is not always so. Pleasure is an internal feeling or reaction to an external event. Its only form of measurement is subjective to the agent and thus has no external uniformity as seen by some people finding pleasure in certain actions while others are bored by that same action. Warren recommends the quiet life since it involves less pleasure and pain overall, leading to a more virtuous form of existence. His view on the quiet life reflects Plato's writing from millenia ago: "Excessive laughter [pleasure] and tears [pain] must be avoided, and this is the advice every man must give to each other; one should try to behave decently by suppressing all extremes of joy and grief, both when one's guardian angel brings continued prosperity and when in times of trouble our guardians face difficulties as insurmountable as a higher sheer cliff.⁵" To behave decently and uniformly in all circumstances, good and bad, is that of stoic virtue. Plato's talk of guardian angels suggests his views have a religious motivation to trust in the gods to handle large scale pleasures and pains and to personally deal with the smaller, mortal pleasures and pains by living with virtue. Holding virtue as the main aim in life leads to what's best and most pleasurable better than if one aims at pleasure. For if one's character is dictated by subjective pleasure experiences rather than objective virtue, it would be easy to fall into the vices that come with prosperity and the lows of despair. By pursuing a quiet life, an individual is able to remain virtuous and rational during despair and prosperity without giving in to the temptation that comes along with them. The

⁵ Plato, Laws V pp. 1414, 732c1-5

Calliclean life can grow into uncontrolled disorder if it is under the supervision of a vicious agent since it can be overrun by false pleasure and more pain from one's subjective and possibly incorrect judgement. In the quiet life, false pleasures are unable to predominate because the quiet life is dominated by the virtues, which are all objective and true. More pleasure is thus found in the quiet life because it is not controlled by the subjective experience of the agent.

Although pleasure is not purely subjective and up to the individual's discretion, there is a large portion of pleasure that is dictated by the individual, unlike virtue which is constant and unchanging. For pleasure to be true and objective, the pleasure must be tied to reason and virtue rather than feeling and opinion. But because humans can be ignorant, mislead, and mistaken, they can misjudge and label false pleasure as genuine pleasure based on opinion to be a genuine pleasure. According to Plato, a false pleasure stems from a false belief about a pleasure that appears pleasurable but is grounded in a misunderstanding of reality. An example of this is how injustice seems pleasant to the evil person who mislabels evil and bad things as a form of good. Plato writes: "Injustice looks pleasant to the enemy of justice, because he regards it from his own personal standpoint, which is unjust and evil; justice, on the other hand, looks unpleasant to him. But from the standpoint of the just man the view gained of justice and injustice is always the opposite."⁶ False pleasures can deceive what an individual perceives as pleasurable because pleasure is connected to his or her opinion about what is best and what is pleasurable. In the Philebus choice of lives ranking, Protarchus clearly articulates this idea: "For pleasure seems to be the greatest imposter of all, by general account, and in connection with the pleasures of love, which seem to be the greatest of all, even perjury is pardoned by the gods. Pleasures are perhaps like children who don't possess the least bit of reason. Reason, by contrast, either is the same as

⁶ Plato, Laws II pp. 1354 (663c3-7)

truth or of all things it is most like it and most true.”⁷ Plato states how pleasure can lack reason and as a result be far from the truth and the form of the good. For it is through reason, and more specifically a properly functioning, unilluded capacity for reason, that virtue is possessed, according to Plato. Through living with reason and virtue, the rational part of the soul dominates and the spirited part of the soul supports while the appetitive part of the soul obeys with no capacity to grow out of control. However, as the Philebus quote states, most people, especially children, do not have the capacity for reason without errors in judgement, and thus, are subject to the appetitive part of the soul where pleasure, typically false pleasures, can dominate. It is objective pleasure that is obtained through virtue and objective pleasure also displays what is truly best through the form of what is good.

It is through achieving what is objectively good that we find objective, true pleasure. What is objectively good can be determined through virtue. The virtues include: wisdom, courage, temperance, and justice. In the Laws, Plato focuses on justice, however, his arguments and positions could and should be extended to include all virtues. Each virtue and virtue itself is not a matter of opinion or subjective feeling. Virtue is grounded in reason, order, and truth, making it objective. While virtue is experienced and can be debated, virtue is an objective standard regardless of what a person's rationale concludes. This logic also applies to the good. Even though a person is at liberty to judge what he or she thinks is good and bad, there still remains an objective good. “What gives truth to the things known and the power to know to the knower is the form of the good. And though [the form of the good] is the cause of knowledge and truth, it is also an object of knowledge. Both knowledge and truth are beautiful things, but the good is other and more beautiful than they.”⁸ Plato states in the Republic that the good is

⁷ Plato, Philebus pp. 454 (65c4-d2)

⁸ Plato, Republic VI pp. 1129 (508d9-e4)

more beautiful and can be determined to be what is best for each individual. From this, he argues that what is best for a city is for it to be governed by virtue. The same logic can be applied to individuals since it is the individuals who govern and live within the city. Therefore, it is better for a person to pursue virtue instead of pleasure as pleasure can be deceptively labelled as what is best while not truthfully being best.

Because virtue is objective and best, it serves as the clearest indicator of true pleasure, even surpassing pleasure itself as a guide to pleasure. Since pleasure has already been proven to be misleading at times and to certain agents (namely kids and “bad” agents), it can be established that leading a life where one constantly pursues pleasure may not lead to the most pleasurable life. On the other hand, virtue and its relationship to what is good and best will never deceive an agent who is pursuing pleasure due to virtue's objective and logically sound nature. Virtue presents itself as a more effective indicator at what true pleasure is because it enhances the discernment of one's soul to be truth seeking, rational, and fulfilling. As a result, a soul guided properly by virtue will be better at pleasure seeking than a soul without virtue. The Athenian considers the judgement of the *better soul* to have a better claim at being correct about what is good. This view extends to the virtues where better can mean wisdom, justice, temperance, pious, and courage. Trusting individuals who possess these virtues is a common practice. We trust the just judge, the wise teacher, the courageous warrior, the pious priest, and the temperate businessman more than we trust their opposites. For it is their virtue that makes them trustworthy and their virtue which brings about their own pleasure. Not only are people more likely to trust the just judge, but the just judge is also given pleasure by his own sense of justice. People who listen to or follow him will find pleasure and comfort in the judge's expertise and advice because of his objective virtue which brings about his prestige. Plato would support this realization based

on his writing that: “It is equally certain that the unjust life is not only more shocking and disgraceful, but also less pleasant, than the just and holy.”⁹ The just and the holy relate to the people who possess the virtues of justice and piety. Pursuing pleasure does not revolve around virtue and can lead to an unjust life or life of vice. However, a life of virtue will take into account the pleasure of the agent as well as what is best for their soul. It is through satisfying the soul and eudaimonia that one can safely maximize their pleasure. Thus, a person ought to treat virtue as the object of pursuit in their life rather than pleasure in order to optimize their sense and actuality of true, fulfilling pleasure.

Treating virtue as the object of pursuit gathers the most pleasure because it accounts for all parts of the soul and allows an individual to satisfy all of his or her needs beyond merely pleasure. While pleasure is important, pleasure by itself is not of foremost importance. Prioritizing pleasure over pain is human and rational. But prioritizing pleasure over everything else is hedonic and not ideal for optimizing happiness or even pleasure. By prioritizing virtue, one maximizes pleasure since virtue cares for the whole person and allows other parts of the soul and character to be holistic and fulfilled. A prominent Latin and Jesuit phrase that particularly comes to mind when reading Plato’s description of virtue and eudaimonia is “cura personalis.”¹⁰ Cura personalis is very similar to eudaimonia in that it suggests one takes care and respects all aspects of oneself in order to live a fulfilling life. Plato claims that care for the whole character and truth, which is achieved through a virtuous life, is better than a life aimed at pleasure alone. A person ought to pursue this type of holistic and virtuous life as he writes: “The life of physical

⁹ Plato, *Laws II* pp. 1354 (663c9-d4)

¹⁰ My familiarity with “cura personalis” stems from my Jesuit high school education. It was instilled in the young men of high school that we care and respect all parts of our soul, mind, and body. This core tenet of the Jesuits fascinatingly ties into this argument especially since it was instilled in me during my youth education and Plato talks about how it is important to educate the youth to find pleasure in the good and virtuous in *Laws II* 664b-c.

fitness, and spiritual virtue too, is not only pleasanter than the life of depravity but superior in other ways as well: it makes for beauty, an upright posture, efficiency, and a good reputation, so that if a man lives a life like that it will make his whole existence infinitely happier than his opposites number.”¹¹ It is through the good and benefits from achieving the good that pleasure arises in its truest form. Good is achieved by pursuing virtue. Pursuing virtue enables other aspects of our lives— namely our souls, reputation, posture, morality, fitness, and other aspects of our lives— to be fulfilled and taken pleasure in. This list of aspects to take pleasure in from Plato seem to encourage the pursuits of the renaissance man.¹² By today’s standards, a close representation of a renaissance man is a well-rounded university student— a young philosopher that demonstrates spiritual awareness, intellectual capacity, physical prowess, and a charming character. All of these aspects are associated with pleasure, but are not perceived as pleasure unless an individual’s subjective experiences lead them to label them as good and pleasurable pursuits. The form of the good cannot be influenced by subjective experience. Thus, to enhance the good in one’s life, one ought to pursue virtue rather than pleasure. In eudaimonia, cura personalis, and Plato’s writing, pleasure is subordinate to the good. Through pursuing a virtuous life, pleasure and benefit will be found through the good. Pleasure ought to be found through the good because the good does not change, is best, and will not deceive. Virtue brings the good into one's life and with the good comes the benefit of pleasure.

The questions Plato raises causes an investigation into an important distinction that initially sparks the dialectic about virtue versus pleasure. “Is the life of supreme justice also the life that gives utmost pleasure? Or are there two kinds of life, one being “the supremely just,” the other “the most pleasurable?”¹³ The Athenian response to his own (Plato’s) questions are that

¹¹ Plato, Laws V pp. 1416 (734d6-e2)

¹² Renaissance man is defined by Google as a person with many talents or areas of knowledge.

¹³ Plato, Laws II pp. 1353, 662d1-3

there are not two different lives and that the supremely just life is the life of the purest, truest, and utmost pleasure. True pleasure depends upon virtue and the good of the soul, rather than the appetite and appearance of basic pleasure. Individuals can debate upon what they believe virtue and justice to be, however, their decisions and opinions do not play a factor into what virtue and justice truly are. Virtue is the proper result of reason governing the soul and reason has the capacity to judge correctness of pleasures independently from personal desire. Pleasure without virtue can be misleading and contrary to the good. Taking pleasure in a false pleasure is never attributable to a pursuit of virtue, but rather it will always be due to blind judgment and deception of opinion via pleasure. The pursuit of virtue only leads to true pleasures since virtue is rooted from reason and objective truth. Pleasure without virtue can cause the appetite to run rampant and make one susceptible to taking pleasure in a false pleasure. Thus, can there really be a life with utmost pleasure that is not also supremely just and virtuous? Plato correctly claims not. In the life of utmost pleasure, the pursuit must be virtue because pleasure does not exist through itself. Pleasure must exist or be taken in things, activities, people etc. A virtuous life, with virtue as the main object of pursuit, allows us to rationally discern true pleasures for ourselves. Since the virtue and forms of the good are objective, a virtuous life allows us to distinguish these from their opposites and live a life that is pleasurable amongst other qualities that lead to a more pleasurable life by obtaining. The virtuous life is the life that we ought to live for the sake of virtue itself, but also self fulfillment since the virtuous life promotes harmony and morals that are beneficial and pleasurable not only for the individual but for society as a whole.

A virtuous life is the life that produces the utmost pleasure. The life of supreme justice for the virtuous person yields the life of utmost pleasure, thus the two lives are inseparable. The rationale of a life in pursuit of virtue is based on objective truth and reason. More objective form

of the good is achieved which allows the soul to be fulfilled. This consequence produces the benefits of other forms within the characters that bear pleasure as a fruit. Pleasure alone satisfies the appetite of the soul while virtue can fulfill the spirit and reason of the soul as well as the appetite. Virtue cannot be deceived from false pleasures and subjective experience and is constant across all boundaries. The life of virtue has the greatest choiceworthiness and ought to be followed by all individuals for the benefit of the self, others, and society.

Works Cited

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